

The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Thursday, May 31, 2018, in the Council Chambers of City Hall.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Lovett at 6:30 p.m.

Members of the Council present were:

At-Large Councilor Claire Lessard
Ward I Councilor Andrew O'Hearne
Ward III Councilor Jonathan Stone
Assistant Mayor Allen Damren
Mayor Charlene Lovett
At-Large Councilor Jeremy Zullo
At-Large Councilor Abigail Kier
At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski
Ward II Councilor Scott Pope

Also present:

Ryan McNutt, City Manager

AGENDA CHANGES

None

CITIZEN'S FORUM

No one spoke.

NON-PUBLIC SESSION PURSUANT TO RSA 91-A:3,II(d) – REAL ESTATE

At 6:31 p.m., a motion was made by Mr. O'Hearne and seconded by Ms. Kier to enter into the Non-Public Session pursuant to RSA 91-A:3,II(d) – Real Estate and to invite Ms. Russell, Mr. McNutt and Ms. Walter into the session.

Roll call vote:

**Lessard - yes
O'Hearne - yes
Stone - yes
Damren - yes
Zullo - yes
Kier - yes
Koloski - yes
Pope - yes**

Lovett – yes
Motion carried 9-0.

At 7:12 p.m., a motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Mr. O’Hearne to exit the Non-Public Session.

Roll call vote:
Lessard - yes
O’Hearne - yes
Stone - yes
Damren - yes
Zullo - yes
Kier - yes
Koloski - yes
Pope - yes
Lovett – yes
Motion carried 9-0.

A motion was made by Ms. Kier and seconded by Mr. Stone to seal the minutes because it is determined that divulgence of this information is likely to render a proposed action ineffective.

Roll call vote:
Lessard - yes
O’Hearne - yes
Stone - yes
Damren - yes
Zullo - yes
Kier - yes
Koloski - yes
Pope - yes
Lovett – yes
Motion carried 9-0.

BUDGET

Budget Discussion

Revenues

Councilors felt the City’s Revenues were too low and they were discussing adding \$290,000 to them. Ms. Walter said if the Revenues are increased, there won’t be as much money at the end of the budget year to put into Fund Balance.

Mr. McNutt said if the amounts stay as was proposed and revenues come in higher, then as we get closer to fall, we could reduce the tax increase.

Mr. Damren felt that increasing the Revenues would help ease residents' tax burden.

Ms. Walter said with expenses, you have more control, but not with revenues. She said in the FY 16 audit, there was only \$59,000 left in the bottom line, which is very close.

Regarding Revenues, it was the consensus of the Council to add \$290,000 to the bottom line and that Mr. McNutt and Ms. Walter would use their experience to propose what line items to add it to. Ms. Walter said the \$290,000 increase in Revenues would give us a tax rate of \$15.24 which is 41 cents less than the City Manager's proposed increase, or 40 cents increase over last year's tax rate.

Policy

There was a discussion of Misc Expenses – Council Requests and Misc Expenses – Board Requests. Ms. Walter said the boards typically don't spend all their money. At some point there will be a need to save money for ADA accessibility issues in Council Chambers.

There was discussion about the part-time legal and part-time administrative position. Ms. Walter said \$90,000 has been budgeted for salary and benefits. Mayor Lovett felt it was not necessary to fill that position at this time as the City has been living without it.

Mr. McNutt said the ideal person would have some legal background and would assist other departments such as Human Resources, the City Manager's office, and would be a City Hall "administrative floater."

Ms. Walter said all other departments have been trying to do the jobs that Legal was doing. It has been challenging without in-house legal assistance.

Mr. Damren proposed starting the position October 1. Mr. McNutt sees that as a reasonable compromise. Ms. Walter said with starting later in the year, \$20,700 could be cut from that line.

Mr. Zullo said he had a hard time creating a position with the current tax increase and thus far we have gotten by without the position.

Mr. McNutt sees the stress of employees doing more with less. He sees the benefit of bringing this position onboard.

Mr. Koloski said he doesn't know enough to support this position.

Mr. McNutt said the amount spent on Legal in 2016 was \$157,000 and in 2017 was \$168,000. The proposed budget for 2018 is \$99,000 plus \$70,000 (legal/admin person) for a total of \$169,000.

Ms. Walter said this position is budgeted for full-time.

A motion was made by Mr. Stone and seconded by Mr. O'Hearne to table the discussion of the legal person pending receipt of more information such as a job description, clear definition of the position, job title, etc.

Voice vote: motion carried 7-2 with Mr. Damren and Ms. Kier voting no.

City Administration

There was a brief discussion on a few items for clarification.

Elections

Mr. Koloski would like to see some money invested to remind people to vote. Mr. McNutt said Fire and Public Works are working toward getting electronic signs and we can see if they can be used to remind people to vote.

Assessing

There was a brief discussion about the revaluation. Mr. McNutt said it has to be done by April 1, 2019.

Municipal Complex

Ms. Walter said Municipal Complex General Supplies could be reduced \$3,000 and still be safe. Mayor Lovett said that bottom line would be \$506,932.

Planning & Development

Mr. Koloski asked if the phone system can be changed for the Planning and Development office. When you go into the automated system, it's not clear which number to push.

There was a brief discussion that people like to see rope lights on the poles and in the trees in the downtown.

There was a discussion about the \$100,000 for pre-engineering study for Pleasant Street. Mayor Lovett wanted any leftover money to go toward roads. Ms. Walter cautioned that the money is coming from Fund Balance and we don't normally do paving with money from Fund Balance. Mr. McNutt doesn't think there will be any money left from the \$100,000, but if there is, it can be discussed.

General Services

Mayor Lovett said this would have a bottom line adjustment of \$4,000 less. Mr. Damren said the total bottom line would be \$1,244,654.

Communication 911

There was a brief discussion for clarification.

Police

Ms. Kier asked if there is any wiggle room in the Police Special Events line in order to reduce it.

Fire

Ms. Kier asked about reducing Fire Training & Employee Development. Mr. McNutt said he can inquire to see who is going to what training.

There was a discussion about the lack of use of the Fire Civil Defense line. Mr. McNutt said he is fine with cutting it. He will check with the Fire Chief to make sure it is not needed.

There was a discussion about Street Lighting – Traffic Signals and Mayor Lovett suggested reducing that amount by \$1,000.

Welfare

No discussion.

Sanitation

Mr. McNutt said he and Public Works Director Scott Sweet agreed the right amount has been budgeted.

Mr. Pope asked if it would be prudent to get the Transfer Station Ad Hoc Committee back together. Mr. McNutt thinks it would be beneficial as a lot of things Mr. Sweet will be doing, the public will need to be educated about. The Committee will be helpful getting the information out.

Mayor Lovett said she is not sure there is enough time because she was the Chair of the Transfer Station Ad Hoc Committee and now the Finance Committee, which she is a member of, is going section-by-section through the City Fee Schedule.

Streets & Roads

Mayor Lovett said she is assuming that any money Mr. Sweet has left over, he will encumber to put toward roads.

Mr. McNutt said the Council had recommended to add in \$115,000 to the budget for maintaining the roads done with the road bond money, but he asked where it will come from. There were no recommendations. Mr. McNutt said it would either be raised and appropriated on the tax rate or it would come from Fund Balance.

Regarding putting money toward crack filling, chip sealing, etc., of the roads that were done with the road bond money, Ms. Walter said the Police Department is going to be underspent this year. She suggested Council make a motion to encumber a certain amount of that money for this work.

Library

Mr. McNutt noted the Council had wanted to add \$500 to the Library's bottom line for Microfilming/Digitization of Records making the total bottom line \$403,283.

Debt Retirement

No discussion.

Cemetery

Brief discussion for clarification.

Airport

Mr. McNutt talked about the \$12,500 for Consulting Services. He said there are an incredible amount of duties at the Airport that take time away from the duties of the Fire Chief. The Airport can support this and there is someone willing to do it. The personnel at the Airport are aged and it would be beneficial to have an Airport Manager. Ms. Walter said there is a big project coming up.

Ms. Walter said the goal is to make the Airport self-sustaining, but it is not there, yet.

Regarding the \$12,500 in the Consulting Services line of the Airport budget, Mayor Lovett asked Mr. McNutt to ask the potential consultant's opinion if they have the capability to bring in \$12,500 revenue to offset that cost.

Parks

Council had originally requested to reduce Parks Part Time by \$5,000. It was the consensus of the Council to change the reduction from \$5,000 to \$4,500 making the bottom line \$397,213 and

to add a line for Rail Trail and to put \$500 in it. Ms. Walter said she will add a line item for the \$500.

CSB – Recreation

No discussion.

Outside Agency

No discussion.

Mayor Lovett asked for the bottom line changes to be sent to the Council.

The Council did not complete its review of all of the budget line items, so it was agreed the June 13 Council meeting would start at 5:30 p.m. in order to finish this before the Budget Hearing and Vote.

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None

ADJOURNMENT

At 10:14 p.m., a motion was made by Mr. O’Hearne and seconded by Mr. Zullo to adjourn.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

Respectfully Submitted,

Dorée M. Russell
Clerk to the Council